four essential human freedoms' that would form a 'definite basis for a kind of world attainable in our own time and generation'. These were the freedom of speech and expression, freedom to worship, freedom from want, and freedom from fear, and as Roosevelt repeatedly emphasized, these were possible 'everywhere in the world'. [2] Roosevelt's neo-liberal vision was very much at odds with the then-dominant notions of colonialism, communism and fascism.

The Cold War era that followed World War II was a dangerous time. In direct dealings between the Soviet Union and the United States—such as in Europe—an unstable peace was preserved. This was in large part due to the presence of nuclear weapons and strong alliances on both sides. The United States had demonstrated the terrible, destructive power of nuclear weapons by using them on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1945. After the Soviet Union acquired and tested its own nuclear weapons in 1949, a massive arms race ensued between the United States and the Soviet Union during which thousands of nuclear weapons were aimed by the superpowers at each other, including in close proximity to one another in Europe. As the two sides deterred each other—not wanting to fire the first shot of what could result in mutually assured destruction—their competition took other forms. Spy games driven by intelligence concerns and matters of prestige (such as the 'space race') featured prominently. Both sides also advanced their economic models. The United States unveiled the ambitious Marshall Plan, a massive aid project that saved Western Europe from famine in the late 1940s, but also deliberately checked the advance of communism. [3] It also established the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), a mutual defence treaty of European and North American countries to defend against the Soviet Union. The USSR, meanwhile, promoted its own state-led industrial model among its Warsaw Pact allies in Central and Eastern Europe.

While the international system was being primarily defined and shaped by the superpower rivalry, another major development was unfolding. This was the decolonization of much of the world, from South and Southeast Asia to Africa and from the Caribbean to the South Pacific and West Asia. (South and Central America had mostly decolonized in the nineteenth